

Should we be evaluating initiatives and programs or components or streams within overall initiatives?

The Strategic Evaluation Approach (G2) suggests prioritizing evaluation questions based on the strategic knowledge needs of a sector, rather than solely on the characteristics of individual initiatives. Where feasible, it is also better to think in terms of evaluating individual components or strands of programs rather than entire initiatives. The combination of elements in a program can be somewhat arbitrary, shaped by the disciplinary background of those involved, their prior experience, or the institutional setting of the provider.

If an initiative consists of three strands, it is more useful to know whether all three work than simply that the initiative as a whole works. The true efficacy of a component could be hidden if one strand benefits participants while another has a negative impact. From a cost–benefit perspective, an initiative with three strands, where only one is effective, might appear to cost three times more than if only the effective strand were implemented. In addition, with the change of political administrations, it is sometimes the case that the name of a particular initiative becomes politically unpalatable because of its association with a previous administration. However, some of the separate components, if not identified under the name of the overall initiative, could still be acceptable to the incoming administration. Using the analogy of a drug trial, most social and community sector initiatives resemble testing a cocktail of drugs rather than a single drug.

This is, however, a complex area. There may be synergy between components, making them more effective together than alone. Some components, while not particularly effective themselves, may be essential for gaining community support for other components. Suppliers/providers experienced in a set of interventions may resist limiting themselves to a single component. Furthermore, evaluating individual components will be more expensive, as it requires separate impact evaluations for each.

For these reasons, evaluating components separately is often a long-term goal rather than an immediate reality. In the meantime, when constructing DoView strategy/outcomes diagrams, it is helpful to break down the components of an initiative and map the outcomes each is expected to influence, fostering a view of initiatives as composed of distinct parts.

Source: DOVIEW PLANNING AND PRACTICAL OUTCOMES THEORY HANDBOOK (2025). DoView Planning.Org. Copyright Dr Paul W Duignan.